

CHAPTER TWO

Emotions Are Information

In the second week of school, Sofia's stomach hurt during a math test. This was not new. Sofia's stomach had hurt during math tests since kindergarten. What was new, this year, was that Sofia knew what to do about it.

She was in the middle of a problem about how many apples Henry had if he gave four away to his sister and three to his cousin and started with twelve, and she felt the small tight feeling start in her belly, the one that meant *I am scared I am going to mess up*. In first grade, she had not had a name for the feeling. By third grade, on a Tuesday morning two weeks into the school year, she knew exactly what it was.

She put her pencil down. She put her hand on her stomach. She took a slow breath.

In her head, she said: *Hi, stomach. I see you. What are you telling me?*

The stomach said, in its own small stomach voice: *I am scared I won't get the right answer. I am scared everyone will know I got it wrong.*

Sofia said back: *Okay. Thank you for telling me. I hear you. I am going to do the problem the way I know how, and if I get it wrong I will still be okay. Worst case is wrong, not catastrophe. We are okay.*

She picked her pencil back up.

She solved the problem. She got it right. (Henry had five apples.) By the time the test was over, she had solved nineteen of the twenty problems. She had no idea if any of them were right except the apple one, but she also did not feel like she was going to throw up, which was a much better situation than she would have been in two years ago.

This is the thing about Sofia. She had been quietly building, since first grade, a tiny instruction manual in her head for how to deal with her stomach. She had not told anyone. It was just hers. By third grade, she had pages and pages of it.

She did not know that what she had been building had a name.

On Friday morning, Ms. Calloway came in for the second SEL lesson of the year, and the name showed up.

"Friends," said Ms. Calloway, "today we are going to talk about emotions. About all of them. The good ones and the hard ones."

The kids settled in. Some of them — the ones who had not been in her class — looked a little wary. Talking about emotions, for some of them, was a thing that had only ever been done at a doctor's office, or in trouble, or never.

But Marcus and Amara and Sofia and Priya and Darius and Jordan and Maya and Theo and Kezia — they leaned in. They knew this lesson. They knew the shape of it.

"There is an old way of thinking about emotions," said Ms. Calloway. "The old way is that some emotions are good — happy, excited, proud — and some are bad — sad, angry, scared. The old way thinks bad emotions are something to make go away."

She wrote on the board:

OLD WAY: *Some emotions are bad. Get rid of them.*

She drew a line through it.

"That is not how it actually works. Here is the new way. Emotions are not good or bad. Emotions are information. Every emotion is telling you something true about your situation. Your job is not to make the emotion go away. Your job is to listen to what it is telling you."

She wrote on the board:

NEW WAY: Emotions are information. Listen to what they are telling you.

Sofia, in her seat, felt something click. She had been doing the new way for two years without knowing there was a name for it. Now there was a name for it. The name felt like being seen.

"Let's go through a few," said Ms. Calloway.

She made a chart on the board.

Sadness – tells you something or someone you love is gone, hurt, or far away. Lets you know what matters.

Anger – tells you a boundary has been crossed, or something is unfair. Lets you know what you are willing to defend.

Fear – tells you there might be danger. Lets you know what you want to keep safe.

Anxiety – tells you that you care about something coming up, and you don't know how it will turn out. Lets you know what is at stake.

Shame – this one is trickier. Sometimes shame is information – sometimes it is telling you that you did something that doesn't fit with your values, and you can repair it. But sometimes shame is lying. Sometimes shame says you are bad as a person, not that you did something bad. We are going to spend a whole lesson on this one later in the year.

Joy – tells you what is working, what to do more of, what is alive.

Loneliness – tells you that you need connection, and need to reach for it.

Marcus stared at the chart.

He thought about being mad at the bus kid for asking if comics were babyish. He had been mad. He had also been a little scared. He had also been, he realized now, ashamed — a feeling he had not given a name to before. He had walked home from the bus with all three feelings sitting in his chest and he had thought *what is wrong with me*, and now Ms. Calloway was telling him that nothing was wrong with him. The feelings were giving him information about what mattered.

The information was: *I care about my comic. I do not want to give it up. I do not want to feel small for liking it.*

That was useful information. He had not known that useful information was something a feeling could give him.

Ms. Calloway said, "Emotions are not your enemies. They are not even your friends. They are messengers. They have a job — to tell you what is happening in your inner world. You can argue with the messenger, or you can listen to the message. The kids who learn to listen have an advantage that lasts their whole life."

She paused.

"Some of you have already been listening. You have been doing this for a while. You taught yourselves. To those kids — well done. You are ahead of most adults."

Sofia did not look up, but she could feel that Ms. Calloway might be looking at her. She did not need to check. The being-known feeling was the whole gift.

"Some of you are just starting. That is also good. You are starting young. By the time you are forty, you will be very good at this. Adults who didn't learn it until they were forty will look

at you and wonder how you got so wise. The answer is — you started when you were eight."

She handed out a worksheet with three columns.

A FEELING I HAVE BEEN HAVING THIS WEEK.

WHAT THE FEELING MIGHT BE TELLING ME.

WHAT I AM GOING TO DO WITH THAT INFORMATION.

The kids worked on it quietly for fifteen minutes.

Marcus wrote, in column one: *Embarrassment about my comic.* In column two: *I care about my comic. I don't want to lose the parts of me I love just because somebody older said they were babyish.* In column three: *Keep drawing the comic. Maybe show it to someone I trust. Not show it to the kid on the bus.*

He felt about thirty percent better than he had felt in the morning, and he hadn't even done anything yet. The act of naming what he was feeling, and turning the feeling into information, and then turning the information into a plan, had taken some weight off his chest.

This is what the lesson was for.

Sofia, across the room, wrote:

A feeling I have been having: worry about math tests.

What it is telling me: I want to do well. I care.

What I am going to do with it: Tell my stomach thank you. Do the test the way I know how. Remember that wrong is okay, not the end of the world.

She looked at her three columns. Then she did something nobody else in the room did.

She wrote, at the bottom, in tiny handwriting:

I have been doing this for a while. I am proud of me.

She underlined it. She put the worksheet in her folder.

At the very end of the lesson, Ms. Calloway said one more thing. "Friends. Some emotions are easy to listen to. Some are very hard. Sometimes the message is something you do not

want to hear. Loneliness might be telling you that you need to reach for someone, and you are scared to. Shame might be telling you that you did something you need to repair, and you are scared to. Anger might be telling you about a person in your life you have been pretending is okay, and they are not."

"When the message is hard, please remember — you do not have to listen alone. You can tell a trusted adult what the emotion is telling you, and ask them to help you figure out what to do. The Support Web is real. The Support Web is for hard messages. We are going to talk a lot more about this later in the year."

The class was quiet.

Then the bell rang, and the lesson was over, and Mr. Patel pulled out the math books, and the day went on.

But on the wall, at the back of the room, the index cards from Chapter One were still up. And under them, now, Ms. Calloway had taped up a new chart, in green marker, with the seven emotions on it.

The chart was going to stay there all year. So would the cards. So would Sofia's small private knowledge that she had been doing the right thing all along, and now had a name for it.